They would soon lose two ships, the USS *Houston* and the USS *Rio Escondido*, which carried their supplies of fuel, ammunition, and medicine. Besides, the coral reefs that CIA scouts had mistaken for seaweed prevented the rest of the transport ships from reaching the beaches, and the exiles had to use boats to get there, losing some of their weapons and ammunition in the high water. What they managed to save was wet and often inoperable. Short of weapons, supplies, and ammunition, they were also outnumbered and outgunned once Castro's reinforcements began to arrive at the Bay of Pigs—altogether close to twenty thousand police officers, soldiers, and members of local militias. They were assisted by crews in Soviet-made T-34 tanks.[17]

The CIA asked Kennedy to authorize the use of US airplanes to help the invasion force, but he refused. Dean Rusk of the State Department was furious that by withholding information about the alleged Cuban plane that had landed in Miami, the CIA had put Adlai Stevenson in the position of lying to a world audience. Rusk was now determined to kill CIA plans for any airstrikes that could not be credibly attributed to the planes taking off from airstrips in Cuba. Kennedy, with whom Rusk had spoken by phone after 9:00 p.m. on April 16, was of the same opinion. As far as he was concerned, he had never authorized such strikes and now gave an order to cancel those already planned by the CIA. The CIA had to accept the president's verdict, but, as the landing began in the early hours of April 17, General Charles Cabell of the CIA called Rusk at home and asked him to reconsider. He made the same plea to the president. But the order remained in force: invasion—yes, air support—no. The invaders floundered on the beaches of the Bay of Pigs, fighting now for their lives, not for a chance to break out and launch a nationwide uprising.[18]

On Monday, April 17, Kennedy was back at the White House, keeping his regular schedule of official meetings and meals while trying to figure out what to do next. Bruised politically but not yet militarily, he refused a CIA request to use now camouflaged American bombers to support the struggling troops on the Cuban beaches. But in the early hours of April 19, with things going from bad to worse, he yielded, allowing the use of camouflaged planes piloted by Americans in support of the invaders, but the pilots were not allowed to fight enemy aircraft, and their mission was